We got back to New York at 2:00 p.m. on May 24, and my first action on reaching the Blugerman apartment, after giving everyone a feeble hello, was to remove some of my clothes and tumble into bed and oblivion.

33

The next day, May 25, I made my rounds. I visited the offices of Thrilling Wonder for the first time since I had stormed out with the rejected "Grow Old with Me" seven years before. Merwin was no longer there, of course. The editor was Sam Mines, a tall, husky fellow with a strong jawbone.

I gave him "The Portable Star" and he read it and bought it on the spot.

I then picked up the galleys of Lucky Starr and the Oceans of Venus at Doubleday, and finally went off to dinner with Bob and Ginny Heinlein. I hadn't seen either of them in nine years, not since the end of the Navy Yard days, and this was the first occasion on which I met them as a married couple.

While I suppose Bob was glad to see me on my own account, he had a purpose for the dinner. He knew that Pohl had quit the agency business and he also knew that I had been working agentless since then. As it happened, Bob drew me aside to urge me to become a client of his own agent. He told me very earnestly that his income had quintupled, thanks to his agent. I thought of my own writing income quintupling, and the thought of fifty thousand dollars per year had a vague Olympian quality about it that was endlessly appealing.

I wanted no agent—on principle. Money could not move me.

At least, that was the theory. But fifty thousand dollars a year! I could feel my principles softening about the edges, and I was glad that

the agent would be joining us at dinner. Maybe—if he seemed pleasant —and competent—maybe—just maybe—well, after all, why not. . .

My principles were melting further.

What I needed was something that would jolt me back to my right mind, and fortunately it was supplied me.

I was seated next to the agent's wife, a very talkative woman. She talked about everything in a stream-of-consciousness manner that would have quickly driven me insane if I had listened to her. Fortunately, I had long since